

Welcome to CorpID



Class I · Monday, August 24, 2026

Introductions

Getting to Know You

- State your name
- What you want out of this course
 - What you want to learn
 - What you want to accomplish
 - What you want to gain

Getting To Know Me

- Education
- Work history
- Current situation
- Family
- Hobbies & extras



KURTZ



Course Overview

Corporate Identity Systems

- Not just a logo: a complete system
- Built for one real, local business
- Run a full professional rebrand process
- Portfolio-ready by the end of the semester

Four phases, one semester.

● Discover

Aug 24 – Sep 23

- Research your business & competitors
- Sketch concept directions, narrow to one

● Define

Sep 28 – Oct 14

- Lock the system: color, type, grid
- Write the rationale behind it

● Develop

Oct 19 – Nov 18

- Build applications across every touchpoint
- I-on-I portfolio reviews

● Deliver

Nov 23 – Dec 9

- Finalize the full brand guide
- Present to industry professionals

Schedule may change as we go

Brightspace

- Attendance
- Grades
- Announcements
- That's it

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- Schedule, materials, examples, policies
- Functionally replaces Brightspace
- Let's look at it together right now

Can't Access the Website?

- Tell me anytime
- I'll get you the materials directly

Expectations

How the grade breaks down.

● Mark Comparisons	5%
● High-Contrast Drawings	5%
● System Definition	10%
● Personal Identity	5%
● Brand Guide + Applications	60%
● Process Book	10%
● Final Presentation	5%
● Total	100%

Attendance Policy

- 29 classes, about 79 hours together: make the most of it
- Miss more than 2, your grade starts stepping down
- A lot of people were surprised by that last year

Late Work Policy

- 10% off per class period late
- Nothing accepted after one week
- That means a zero

AI

- University policy applies
- Lots of thoughts on this
- We'll cover it later and throughout

Presentations & Critiques

- Phones down, laptops closed
- Order will be randomized, be ready to present

Portfolio Showpiece

- This becomes a keystone portfolio piece
- Put in the real effort
- This is the one that can help you get a job

Process Over Proof

- Not about "proof": it's about real engagement
- Engage with the process, not just the checklist
- Be curious, make mistakes, change direction
- Actually learn, don't just clear the minimum

Today's Assignments

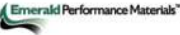
Mark Comparisons

- 10 comparisons, 5 business types
- Good marks: from anywhere
- Bad marks: local only (Akron, Cleveland, Columbus, Pittsburgh)
- This becomes your working pool for the rest of the semester
- Be ready to explain why each mark is good or bad: it shows your taste
- Due Monday, August 31, worth 5%

What this looks like

Mark Comparisons

The Good & Bad of Logo Design

Manufacturing	Non-Profit	Professional	Retail	Service
GOOD  Talkmore is a manufacturer of cellular phones and accessories. This wordmark logo is very successful because it uses a modern, sans serif, lowercase typeface to reach a younger, more technologically inclined audience. Also, it substitutes the letters A and E with quotation marks. The name is still very readable and the addition of the quotation marks in an accent color makes this logotype more interesting and conveys the message of communication.	GOOD  The Memphis Zoo logo incorporates both the monogram letter M as well as the architecture of the structure itself. Even if the viewer has never seen or been to this zoo, they know that it must have some architecture that resembles this iconic mark. The entire logo, both type and image, is encompassed in a nature-alluding green circle. The weight of the icon and the word "zoo" balance out the mark, actually making "Memphis" stand out for it's thinner quality.	GOOD  North River is an investment bank/consulting firm in New York. This logo includes both a monogram and a symbol. The letters N and R can be seen in the mark as well as a swirling shape in the negative space meant to convey the Hudson River. It is more of an abstract symbol, but includes meaningful information as well. It is simple, one color, and bold. Since this company deals with investments and finance it is also an appropriate, professional-looking mark.	GOOD  The Nutty Squirrel logo is a great pairing of appropriate type and image for a specific subject. Gelato is a treat enjoyed by all ages and this icon of a chocolate ice cream squirrel on top of a cone evokes the right playful mood. The typography adds to it by resembling a child's handwriting or like it has been written in messy chocolate script. The logo can be one color or many, making it very versatile. The simplicity of the message and emotion in this mark makes it very strong.	GOOD  This monogram logo for Flipside Entertainment is a successful example of a minimalist take on a complex idea. With three simple lines, this mark displays the letters F, S, and E. It can be done in one color and would still be legible at a small scale even despite it's thin strokes. The typography was created to complement the mark and bring out the letterforms even more by mimicking the same shapes as the letters found in the monogram.
BAD  Emerald Performance Materials is located in Cudahy Falls and produces and markets technologically advanced specialty chemicals for a broad range of food and industrial applications. This logo doesn't do many good things such as the halting gradient, the pretty meaningless symbol, and the predictable use of color. They make so many different chemicals for so many products that there could be some icon that relates better in subject.	BAD  Stewart's Caring Place is a cancer center in Fairtown that provides support and services to individuals touched by cancer and their families. This icon has too many elements, none of which are extremely well-executed. The hand appears arbitrary and the different messages packed into this pictogram are too much. This logo cannot be one color and the green and purple that have been chosen appear too playful and outlandish. A more simplified mark can still be meaningful.	BAD  The Reserve Group is a family based private equity firm that focuses on managing and growing companies. Their tagline, which is "Relationships & Accomplishments," really describes their business ethos. Their current logo looks a little too high and moody for this premise, though. The typography holds a sort of regal air but isn't even serious enough to let their customers know they act professionally. The monogram is plain and meaningless as well.	BAD  Sarah's Vineyard is a winery and art gallery in Cudahy Falls. They have a beautiful vineyard and a sophisticated wine selection, something that is not exemplified in their current logo. The combination of a monogram and an icon is sketchy and informal and does not hold much good meaning. Yes, it shows a grape leaf and vine, but that is the obvious choice. The blue color, on the other hand, doesn't seem to relate to their products that much at all.	BAD  Herbst Electric Company is a team of electricians located in Cleveland who offer field and support services, including 24/7 emergency service. The current wordmark logo seems like a weak concept that has been over-designed. It doesn't hold much meaning but many design tricks have been implemented to turn the simple name into a logo. The tightly kerned, capital sans serif letters make this already foreign word hard to read and don't give any indication to the service offered.

A past student's Mark Comparisons page · corpid.kurtz.cc has more

Personal Identity

- Typographic mark + business card
- Also applies to a resume or letterhead layout
- No fixed checkpoints
- Develop it in parallel, all semester
- Due Wednesday, November 18 (end of Develop), worth 5%

Process Book

- Document everything
- Sketches, dead ends, decisions
- Not just a highlight reel
- Starts today, not week 14
- Log something after every class
- All semester, worth 10%

Before next class

- Mark Comparisons due Monday
- Group review: be ready to talk about it
- Start your Process Book right away
- No class Wednesday, Aug 26

Questions?

See you Monday, August 31.